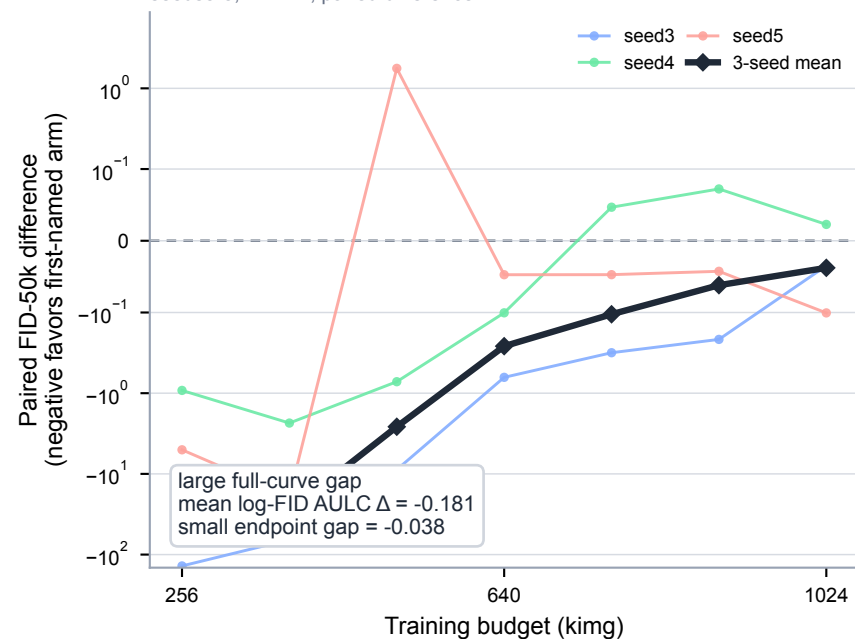


Finite-budget contrasts contract or change sign; one ImageNet seed becomes unstable

Thin colored lines are individual training seeds; the dark line is the stated descriptive mean. Symlog y-scales preserve both near-zero endpoints and large early/unstable excursions.

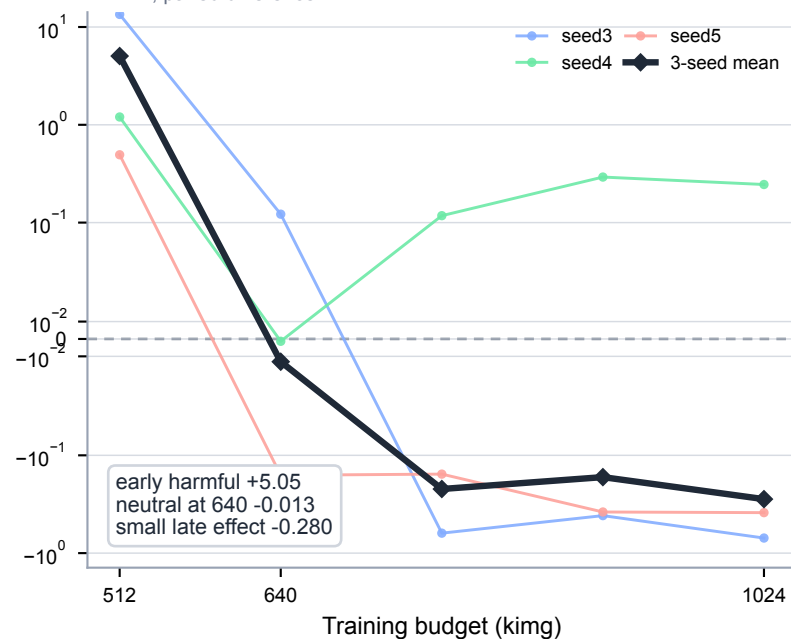
A q256 replay illustration

seeds3-5, NFE=2; paired difference B - A



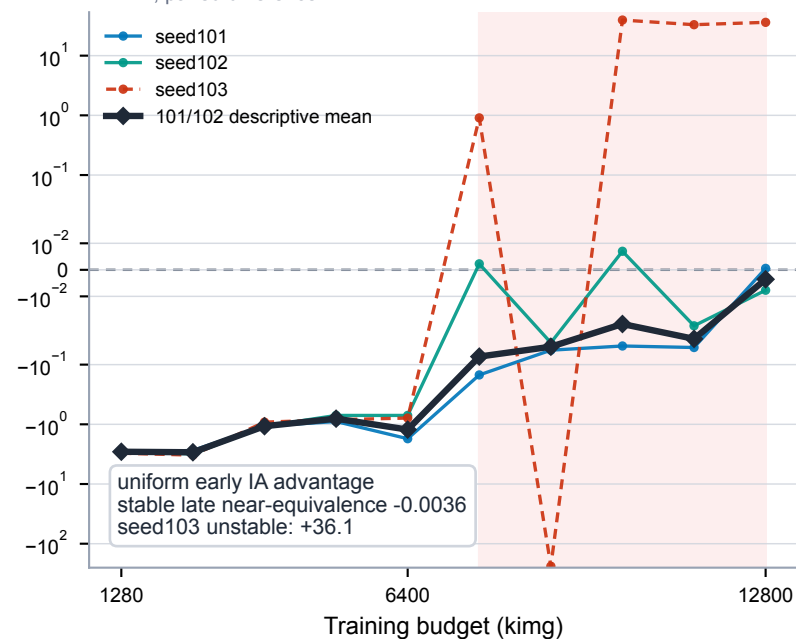
B q128

NFE=1; paired difference B - A



C ImageNet-64

NFE=2; paired difference IA - IB



Note. Panels use different arm contrasts and NFE settings, stated above each axis; the figure compares trajectory shapes rather than a pooled effect. The q256 seed3-5 panel is a replay illustration, not the planned balanced-cohort main result; its AULC is a post hoc descriptive normalized trapezoidal area under log FID. The ImageNet 101/102 mean is a post hoc sensitivity summary; seed103 remains displayed and is not interpreted after instability.